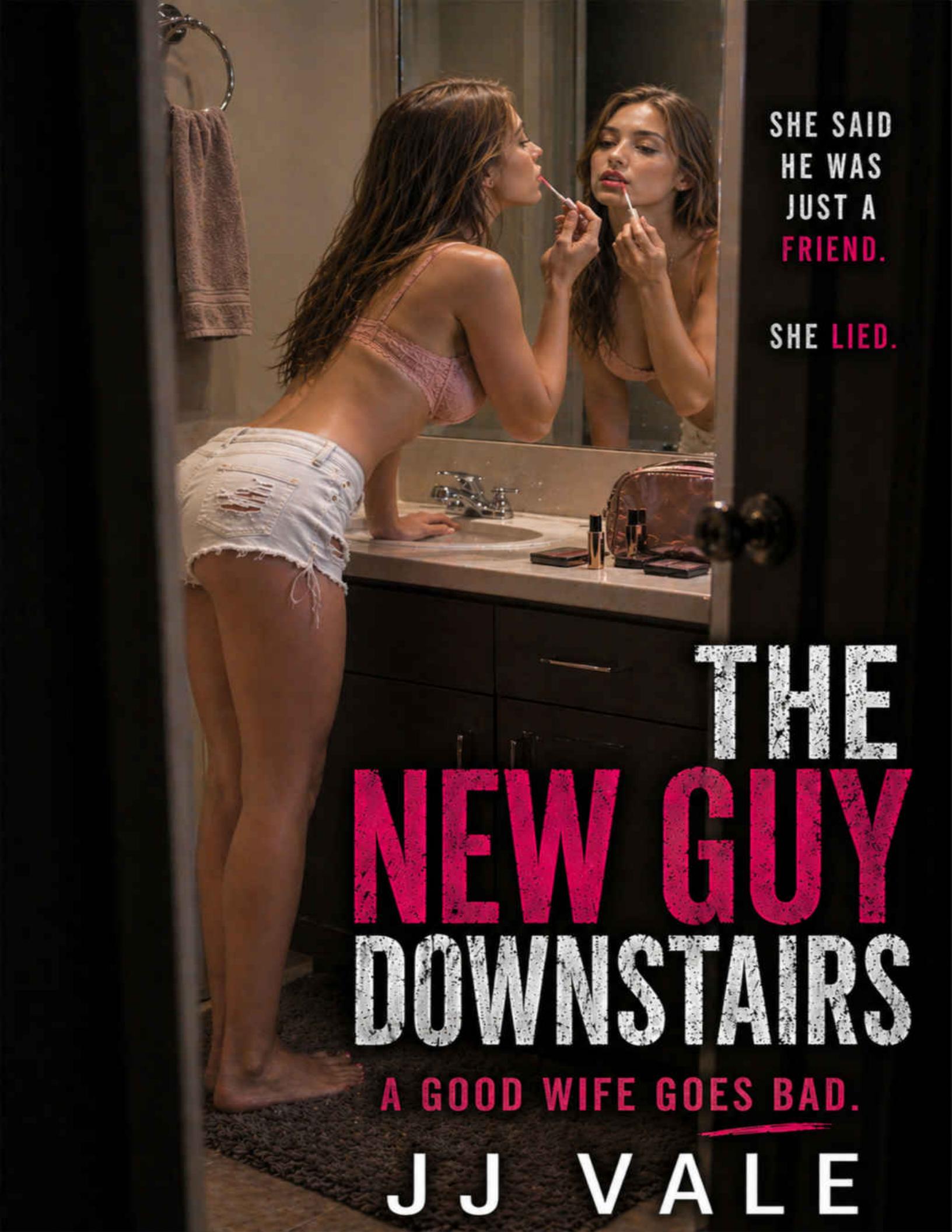


A woman with long brown hair, wearing a pink lace bralette and white denim shorts, is in a bathroom. She is leaning over a white sink, applying pink lipstick while looking into a large mirror. Her reflection is visible in the mirror. The bathroom has dark wood cabinets, a silver faucet, and a brown towel hanging on a ring to the left. Various makeup items are on the counter.

SHE SAID
HE WAS
JUST A
FRIEND.

SHE LIED.

THE NEW GUY DOWNSTAIRS

A GOOD WIFE GOES BAD.

JJ VALE

The New Guy Downstairs

She said he was just a friend. She lied

JJ Vale

PMI

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I liked the predictability of our life together, the way Tuesday always meant Colin worked from home while I went to the office, the way we rotated through the same five dinner recipes without need for discussion. Colin said he loved it too, that we were perfectly matched in our love of routine over chaos. I loved him because it was true.

Our apartment occupied the second floor of a converted Victorian that had been chopped into units decades ago. The layout made no architectural sense, but we'd learned to navigate its quirks. The kitchen was big enough, though we hardly used it. The bathroom had original tile-work that was beautiful but crumbling. We'd learned which tiles were loose enough to avoid stepping on. The living room got great light in the morning but became cave-dark by four in the afternoon. We had lamps on timers.

I worked in billing for a European food import company, processing invoices and tracking payments in spreadsheets that never changed format. Three days a week I went to the office in the city. Two days I worked from our apartment at the small desk we'd wedged into the corner of the bedroom.

Colin tracked shipping routes for an industry research company that compiled data for logistics companies, or something like that. His schedule inverted mine. He was in the office when I was home, home when I was at the office, our paths crossing in the evenings and weekends.

We'd fallen into rhythms that required no negotiations. Colin made coffee in the mornings because he woke first. I did laundry on Sundays because I didn't mind folding clothes while watching a show. We split cleaning based on tolerance rather than fairness, Colin handling the kitchen because, I handled the bathroom because. Our life together worked because we'd eliminated surprise and spontaneity in favor of sustainable pattern.

Monday evening I was updating payments at the bedroom desk while Colin sat in the living room checking on vessel movements across the Atlantic.

We existed in that comfortable parallel focus until my concentration broke from hunger. I saved my work and went to the kitchen to make something for dinner. Colin appeared moments later to get plates and forks out. We made pasta with some jarred sauce a thousand times. I boiled water and heated sauce while Colin cleared the table off.

We ate in front of a show and Colin commented on the poor planning the homeowners showed and I agreed because it was fair. After dinner he did dishes while I wiped the counters. Then we returned to our respective screens until bedtime.

"I'm going to finish this" Colin said around ten, which meant he'd be up another hour.

"I'll probably read for a bit," I said, which meant I'd fall asleep within twenty.

This was our life and I genuinely loved it. I appreciated the lack of drama and upheaval, valued the stability Colin and I had built through compatible temperaments rather than any passionate intensity. We didn't fight because we agreed on most things. We didn't have exciting adventures because neither of us wanted them.

Tuesday morning I woke to Colin already showered and dressed for the office. He kissed my forehead before leaving while I was still half asleep. I got up an hour later and made coffee and settled into the bedroom desk to start processing the previous day's invoices. The work was repetitive but I found the repetition soothing, each line item requiring the same verification, each payment following the same routing through the same accounts.

Around eleven I heard sounds from the building's basement, voices and footsteps and something heavy being dragged across a floor. The basement unit had been empty a few months. I'd grown used to the silence. Now that someone was clearly moving in, I felt mild irritation at the disruption to the building.

I went to the kitchen for more coffee and looked out the window that faced the side of the building where the basement entrance was located. A small moving truck sat at the curb. A man I didn't recognize was carrying boxes down the stairs that led to the basement unit. He looked younger than Colin and me, mid twenties maybe, with longer hair that suggested he either worked somewhere without a dress code or didn't work in a traditional office.

He made multiple trips while I watched from the window. Each load seemed to contain equipment I couldn't identify, large flat cases that might have held artwork or technical gear, boxes labeled with words I couldn't read from this distance, furniture that looked more creative than practical. When he disappeared into the basement with what looked like recording equipment, I returned to my desk and tried to refocus on invoice processing.

The sounds continued throughout the afternoon, occasionally loud enough to penetrate through the floor and interrupt my concentration. Music started playing around two, something with a heavy beat that I could feel more than hear. It continued for an hour before cutting off abruptly. There followed more footsteps, more dragging sounds. Then voices. The new tenant was talking to someone though I couldn't tell if the other person was there or on a phone call.

Colin came home around six and I was in the kitchen starting dinner when he walked through the door looking mildly perplexed.

"Someone's moving into the basement," he said, setting down his bag. "I saw him carrying in computer equipment. A lot of computer equipment."

"I heard him all afternoon," I said. "Music and moving furniture."

"Did you meet him?"

"No. I was working."

Colin joined me in the kitchen and we made dinner together.

After, we were settling in for a relaxing evening of screen time when footsteps sounded on the interior stairs that connected all the units. Someone knocked on our door. Colin and I looked at each other with the shared expression of people whose evening routine had just been intruded on.

Colin opened the door to reveal the same man I'd seen through the window. Up close he looked even younger and more energetic than he'd appeared from above. He wore a graphic t-shirt and jeans with paint stains. His hair was disheveled in a way that looked intentional rather than neglectful. I felt like I knew the type.

"Hey, I'm Javier," he said, extending his hand to Colin and then to me with a big wide smile. "Just moved into the basement. Wanted to introduce myself and apologize in advance for any noise. I sometimes I keep weird hours. Animators, ha!"

Colin shook his hand and introduced us both. I noted the contrast between Colin's careful handshake and Javier's enthusiastic fist bump.

Javier's energy filled our doorway in a way that felt intrusive, his presence already more animated than anyone either of us typically interacted with.

"Animator?" Colin asked. "Like for films?"

"Video games, man," Javier said. "I work for a studio downtown but I do freelance projects too, from home. That's why the weird hours, man. Sometimes I get into a flow at midnight and work through to dawn."

"We'll try to keep it down up here," I said automatically, though we were never loud enough to require keeping down.

"Oh, don't worry about that," Javier said with a grin. "I'm used to working with headphones on. You probably won't even know I'm here most of the time."

He chatted for a few more minutes about the building and the neighborhood. I noticed mostly how expressive his hands were when he talked, how his face showed every thought and reaction without any filters. When he finally said goodnight and headed back down, Colin closed the door and we returned to the couch with big exhaled breath.

"He seems nice enough, though," he said.

"Very energetic," I replied and we both widened our eyes at each other comically.

"At least the basement won't be empty anymore. Better security when you look at it that way."

We resumed our screens and our routines. I had no reason to think that some new person in the basement unit wouldn't change anything about our lives.

Javier knocked on our door again Wednesday evening. When Colin opened it Javier stood there holding a notebook covered in sketches and looking frazzled.

"Sorry to bother you again, man," he said, talking faster yet. "I'm trying to figure out the parking situation. The landlord said something about permits but the email was super vague. Also the internet guy can't come until next week which is a disaster because I have a deadline. I saw you had a router name pop up so I was hoping maybe you could tell me who you use?"

Colin invited him in and they stood in our small entryway while Colin explained the parking permit process and the internet provider options here. I watched from the desk as Javier scribbled notes in his sketch-covered

notebook while simultaneously looking around our apartment with unconcealed curiosity.

"This is a great space," Javier said, his attention moving from Colin to our living room layout. "You've got it set up real nice. My place is tiny, boxes everywhere, I can't find anything. I spent twenty minutes this morning looking for my coffee maker and it turned out I'd packed it with my drawing tablets because they were the same size box." He laughed and knocked his knuckles on his head. "Stupido!"

He laughed in a way that suggested he found it charming and Colin smiled politely and I tried to imagine living in a state where I couldn't locate my coffee maker.

"What kind of animation do you do anyway?" I asked, because Javier's energy was filling our quiet apartment just from his appearance in it. Asking questions seemed like the only response.

His face lit up and he launched into an explanation about character design for an indie game studio, about how he specializes in making movement look natural and expressive, about the difference between animating for cutscenes versus gameplay. He talked with his whole body, hands gesturing to demonstrate concepts, face showing every emotion he described in the characters he created. He was instantly fascinating in a fun-to-visit, can't live there kind of way.

"The thing people don't understand about animation," he said, now fully engaged in a topic that clearly excited him, "is that it's not about making things move realistically. It's about making them move in a way that communicates what the character is feeling. Sometimes you have to exaggerate reality to capture emotional truth."

Colin nodded along though I could tell he was only partially following. But I found myself drawn into Javier's enthusiasm despite the subject being completely outside my wheelhouse. He showed us sketches from his notebook, rough drawings of characters in various poses, and explained what emotions each posture was meant to convey.

"This is really impressive," Colin said, examining a drawing of a character mid-leap. "How long have you been doing this?"

"Since I was a kid basically," Javier said. "Started with terrible anime fan art and somehow turned it into a career. Best decision I ever made was going to art school instead of getting a practical degree like my parents wanted me too." He laughed a full belly laugh at that.

I felt the implicit contrast between his creative career path and our more conventional office jobs. I wondered if he found our lives as incomprehensible as I found his chaos.

Javier's attention shifted to the kitchen visible beyond our living room. He moved toward it without asking, looking at our cooking space with what seemed like genuine appreciation.

"This kitchen is amazing," he said. I nearly laughed because our kitchen was objectively cramped and barely functional. "You've got actual counter space and a decent stove. My basement setup is like a camping kitchenette, two burners and a mini fridge."

"It's really not that big," I said, following him to the kitchen doorway.

"Compared to what I'm working with it's huge," Javier insisted. Then his expression shifted to something that looked like inspiration or impulse. "I should make you guys dinner. As a thank you for helping me figure out the building. I love cooking but I've been living on takeout since I started packing to move. I got no kitchen man!"

The offer caught me off guard and I glanced at Colin, who looked equally uncertain about this spontaneous social proposal from someone we'd known for less than twenty-four hours.

"You don't have to do that," Colin said.

"Man, I want to," Javier said with the same enthusiasm he'd brought to everything. "I'm serious, I love feeding people. How about tomorrow night? I'll bring everything up and cook in your amazing kitchen and you can tell me more about the neighborhood."

I tried to decline but Colin was already agreeing, his natural politeness overriding any hesitation about disrupting our Thursday evening. Javier grinned and said he'd be up around seven.

After Javier left and we heard his footsteps descending to the basement, Colin returned to his shipping manifests and I tried to refocus on expense reports. But after a few minutes of silence I found myself unable to let it pass.

"He's very different from us," I said.

Colin looked up from his screen.

"He's very expressive," I clarified. "Very spontaneous. The complete opposite of how you are."

"That a criticism?" Colin asked. His tone was mild but I heard the real question beneath it.

"No, no," I said, because it wasn't. "Just an observation. He probably thinks we're totally boring."

"We're not boring," Colin said. "We're organized."

I nodded and returned to my work and told myself that one dinner with our energetic basement neighbor wouldn't be a totally bad thing.

Thursday evening I came home from the office to find Colin already there. At seven on the dot Javier knocked on our door and pushed it open himself carrying in two grocery bags. He'd dressed the same as the previous day, casual clothes that looked lived-in and comfortable. His hair was even more disheveled than before. He was a specimen, I had to give him that.

"I'm making this pasta thing I learned from my roommate in art school," Javier announced, heading straight for our kitchen without waiting for invitation. "It's basically Italian comfort food but elevated. You're going to love it."

He unpacked ingredients onto our counter space and immediately began working with the kind of comfortable chaos that made our organized kitchen feel foreign suddenly. He talked while he chopped vegetables, telling stories about his art school roommate and the terrible apartment they'd shared and the cooking experiments that had sometimes succeeded and often failed spectacularly.

"Ashlyn, you come help me with this," Javier said, gesturing me over to where he was dicing tomatoes. "I need you to rip the basil with your hands really really small while I get the pasta water started."

I moved into the kitchen space that suddenly felt smaller with Javier's energy filling it. He positioned me at the counter holding a cutting board while he worked around me. His arm brushed against mine when he reached for olive oil. He laughed when I flinched at the contact.

"Sorry, I'm a close-range cook," he said. "Drives people crazy but I can't help it. It's how we grew up, on top of each other, me and my sisters!"

He showed me how he wanted the basil torn rather than cut, his hands demonstrating the motion and then guiding mine to replicate it. His casual physical contact felt strange after years of only Colin and I moving around each other with careful distance.

"Like this?" I asked, tearing a basil leaf.

"That's perfect, baby," Javier said. He popped a piece of tomato in my mouth before I could react. "You taste that. It's so much better than the grocery store stuff."

The tomato was sweet and acidic and I nodded while chewing. Javier grinned and returned to his chopping. He kept up constant motion and conversation, pulling me into his cooking by asking me to stir things or taste sauces or hold ingredients while he worked under, around, or over me. Each interaction involved some kind of physical contact that felt natural in the moment but that I knew Colin would notice with skeptical eyes.

When the pasta was ready Javier put it on plates with care that contradicted his chaotic cooking style. He fed me a bite straight from the serving spoon before I could grab a fork.

"Good, right?" he asked, watching my face from very close for reaction.

"It's really good," I said. It was, the flavors more complex than anything Colin and I could make.

We sat down to eat and Javier kept the conversation moving, asking about our jobs and our routines and how long we'd lived in the building. He seemed genuinely interested in Colin's shipping logistics work and my billing processes, asking questions that suggested he was actually listening rather than just being polite. He seemed to do everything with intense attention, despite the chaotic look to his ways.

"You two are so organized," Javier said while twirling pasta on his fork. "I bet you have a whole system for everything. Meanwhile I'm still looking for half my stuff in unmarked boxes."

"Yeah, we like systems," Colin said. I heard the mild defensiveness in his tone.

"Nothing wrong with that," Javier said easily. "I wish I was better at it. My life would be less chaotic." He laughed maniacally.

After dinner Javier insisted on doing dishes despite Colin's protests. He pulled me into the kitchen to dry while he washed, continuing his pattern of close-proximity work that kept bringing us into physical contact. Colin glanced from the table with an expression I couldn't quite read. When the kitchen was perfectly, surprisingly, clean, Javier thanked us for letting him cook and headed back downstairs.

"That was actually pretty nice," Colin said after the door closed and the ordeal ended.

"He's very touchy," I said, the observation coming out before I'd decided to say it.

"What do you mean?"

"Just very physical. Lots of physical contact while cooking. He's very different from how we are."

Colin considered this a moment and nodded slowly. "He's probably just used to being around creative type people," he said. "Different culture than where we're from."

I agreed completely and we settled into our evening. But I found myself thinking about Javier's hands guiding mine while tearing basil, about the casual way he'd fed me from the spoon, about how strange it felt to be touched so frequently by someone who wasn't Colin.

The following Tuesday I was working from home while Colin was at his office. Around eleven I went to get the mail and found Javier in the driveway unloading equipment from his car. He'd clearly been up for a while despite the morning hour, dressed in worn jeans and a faded t-shirt with his hair pulled back.

"Good morning," he called to me when he saw me, abandoning his equipment to walk over. "Or is it still morning? I lose track of time when I'm on a project."

"It's eleven-thirty," I said.

"Then technically still morning," Javier said with a grin. "I was up until five working on this character rig. I'm pretty sure I dreamed in wireframes."

He launched into an explanation about the technical challenges of making a character's clothing move naturally while I stood holding flyers in the driveway. I found myself listening despite having work waiting upstairs. Javier had a way of making even incomprehensible technical details sound engaging through sheer enthusiasm.

"Anyway," he said after several minutes, "I should let you get back to whatever you were doing. Are you working from home today?"

"Just billing work," I said. "Nothing exciting."

"Unlike my wireframe dreams," Javier said. His smile made the self-deprecating joke feel warm rather than awkward.

I went back upstairs and tried to refocus on invoice processing, but I found myself checking the window periodically to see if Javier was still in the driveway. He made several more trips carrying equipment before his car was empty and he disappeared into the basement.

Wednesday Colin was home and I was at the office. Thursday our schedules inverted again. I was updating payment records around three when I heard music start playing from the basement, something with a

driving rhythm that filtered through the floor. It continued for an hour before cutting off. Twenty minutes later someone knocked on my door.

Javier stood in the hallway holding a bag of coffee beans.

"I was making a fresh pot and realized I have no idea if you drink coffee," he said. "You want some? I make very good coffee, you'll see."

I thought about it but he already turned and lead the way downstairs, so I had no choice but to follow him to the basement.

It looked completely different from when I'd glimpsed it before his move-in. He'd transformed the cramped space into a functional studio with computer monitors covering one wall, reference images and sketches pinned to every available surface. Furniture arranged for workflow rather than traditional living.

"Sorry about the chaos," Javier said, clearing sketches from a chair so I could sit. "I know where everything is even if it looks like a disaster."

He made coffee and we talked about his current project while I tried not to stare at the dozens of character sketches surrounding us. I realized that being in Javier's space felt completely different from having him in ours. Down here the creative energy that seemed almost intrusive upstairs felt like a pulse down here.

Friday evening Colin and I were settling in to relax and watch shows when Javier texted asking if we had a screwdriver he could borrow. Colin went down to help him with whatever needed fixing. They were gone long enough that I started the show without him.

When Colin returned an hour later he mentioned that Javier had gotten distracted showing him animation software and had completely forgotten about the broken chair leg that had prompted the screwdriver request.

"He's very enthusiastic," Colin said. I couldn't tell if the observation was positive or neutral.

The following week our schedules fell into a pattern where Javier and I were home during overlapping hours while Colin was at the office. I ran into Javier in the driveway Tuesday morning and he asked about my weekend and told me about a gallery opening he went to. The conversation stretched to twenty minutes before I remembered I had work waiting.

Thursday afternoon I was taking a break from billing when Javier knocked. I invited him up without thinking about whether it was appropriate or not. Shut the door behind him. We ended up on the couch together and I put the home reno show back on as though on auto-pilot.

"You like these kind of shows?" Javier asked, watching the screen where people were knocking down walls with sledgehammers.

"I find them relaxing," I said. "The cleaning up parts," I added with a laugh.

"That sounds like the opposite of relaxing to me," Javier said, but his tone was warm.

We talked instead of watching, Javier telling me about his art school years and the terrible jobs he'd worked before breaking into game animation. I found myself sharing details about my work. Javier listened like billing processes were genuinely interesting, asking questions that showed he was trying to understand rather than just being polite. He was strange that way, the way he paid attention to small things.

He moved so much while he talked, shifting positions on the couch, gesturing with his hands, touching my arm to emphasize points, that I worried about getting hit or poked. At one point I was mid-sentence when he reached over and pressed his fingers against my mouth.

"Hold that thought," he said, his hand lingering against my lips. "I want to say, but I'll forget if you keep going."

He removed his hand and launched into his reply. I sat there processing the casual intimacy of being touched like that by someone who wasn't Colin. Javier seemed to think nothing of it, continuing his point while I tried to focus on his words rather than the ghost sensation of his fingers on my mouth.

The conversation continued for over an hour, the show playing through episodes unwatched. When Javier finally said he should get back to work, I realized Colin would be home soon and I hadn't accomplished anything since lunch.

Friday afternoon Javier knocked again. This time when I invited him in, he had his phone in hand and looked hesitant.

"I ask you a favor?" he said. "It's work-related but also kind of weird."

"What kind of favor?"

"I'm working on this character whose main thing is very expressive hand gestures," Javier explained, pulling up reference images on his phone. "And I'm struggling to get the positions right. The stock photo references I'm finding online all look stiff and unnatural."

He showed me examples of what he meant, hands in various poses that did look somehow artificial despite being photographs of real hands.

"I was wondering if you'd let me take some photos of your hands," Javier continued. "Just in different positions, natural gestures. It would really help me get the movement right."

The request felt strange but not unreasonable. I found myself agreeing before I'd fully considered what it might involve.

"Really? That's amazing, thank you," Javier said, his enthusiasm immediate. "This won't take long, I just need like ten or fifteen shots."

He positioned me on the couch with the afternoon light coming through the window. He knelt on the floor in front of me with his phone ready.

"Okay, just relax your hands," Javier said. "Let them rest naturally on your lap."

I did as he asked and he took several photos from different angles, moving around me to capture various perspectives. Then he started giving me directions.

"Can you reach forward like you're taking something from someone?" he asked. I extended my hand and he photographed it. "Great. Now like you're pushing something you don't want away."

I pushed at the air and Javier moved closer to get the angle right, his face inches from my hand while he focused on the screen.

"Turn your palm up," he said. "Like you're asking a question or offering something."

I rotated my hand and Javier reached out and adjusted my fingers, his touch light but sure.

"Perfect, hold that," he said. He took several shots.

He continued giving directions, each one requiring small adjustments that brought him physically closer. At one point he took my hand in both of his to position my fingers the way he wanted. The contact sent an unexpected awareness through me.

"Can you interlace your fingers?" Javier asked. "Like you're thinking or worried about something."

I wove my fingers together and Javier photographed from multiple angles. Then he gently separated my hands and repositioned them.

"This is exactly what I needed," he said, still holding my hands to adjust them. "Your hands are so expressive. Most people's hands look dead when they're posing but yours have this life to them."

His thumbs pressed against my palms while he arranged my fingers. I watched his face while he worked, the concentration in his expression

making the intimate contact feel professional rather than personal.

"Last one," Javier said. "Can you cup your hands like you're holding something precious?"

I formed my hands into a gentle curve and Javier leaned in close to capture the detail, his breath warm against my skin. He took the photo and then looked up at me with a smile.

"Thank you so much," he said, releasing my hands. "This is going to make the character come alive."

He stood and scrolled through the photos while I flexed my fingers, trying to shake the strange awareness that lingered from having been touched and positioned for twenty minutes.

"These are perfect," Javier said, showing me several of the shots. "Look how natural they are compared to the stock photos."

The images did look natural, my hands captured in moments that suggested emotion and intention rather than static poses. Javier thanked me again and headed back downstairs. I sat on the couch for several minutes after processing what just happened.

When Colin came home an hour later I was back at my desk working on billing. When he asked about my day I mentioned that Javier needed reference photos for his animation work. Colin nodded and said that was nice of me to help. We moved on.

That night while Colin was monitoring shipping routes I found myself looking at my hands, trying to see what Javier had seen that made them so expressive. They looked the same as they always had, but I couldn't stop thinking about the way he'd touched them, the way he'd positioned them, the way he'd looked at them like they were special.

The hand photo session must have worked well for Javier's project because three days later he knocked on my door again, this time asking if I'd be willing to model arm positions. Colin was at the office and I was supposed to be processing paperwork, but I found myself saying yes before considering whether I should establish some kind of boundary around these requests.

I enjoyed the hand modeling session, to be honest.

I'd checked my appearance that morning with more care than usual, too, telling myself it had nothing to do with the possibility that Javier might need me for something. I'd worn a fitted shirt instead of my usual loose

work-from-home clothes. I'd put on minimal makeup even though no one would see, me except potentially our basement neighbor.

Javier came upstairs with his phone and a tablet showing the character he was working on, a woman in flowing robes whose every movement needed to convey grace and intention.

"The arms are killing me," he said, showing me animation tests that looked perfectly fine to my untrained eye. "They look mechanical. I need to capture how fabric interacts with natural arm movement, how the weight of cloth changes the gesture."

He'd brought one of his own shirts, something light and oversized. He asked me to put it on over my clothes. The fabric hung loose on my smaller frame. Javier immediately started arranging it, pulling the sleeves up and bunching the material in ways that created the draping effect he was looking for.

"Lift your arm like you're reaching for something on a high shelf," he said, positioning himself behind me with his phone ready.

I raised my arm and felt the fabric shift. Javier moved around me taking photos from multiple angles. His hand touched my elbow to adjust the height. He pulled at the shirt sleeve to create different folds in the material.

"Now reach forward like you're offering something to someone," he said.

I extended my arm and Javier stepped closer to photograph the fabric movement, his face near my shoulder while he focused on the screen. He smelled like coffee and charcoal.

"Beautiful," he murmured, still photographing. "See how the sleeve falls when your arm is extended? That's exactly what I needed. You are so beautiful."

I didn't respond to that. I knew he meant it differently, from a technical art perspective.

He continued directing me through different arm positions. Each one required him to adjust either my posture or the fabric, his hands on my shoulders or my wrists or my waist or hips, moving me into the poses he needed. The contact had become almost constant. I found myself hyper-aware of each touch even as I tried to stay relaxed and natural for his photos. It was becoming normal though.

"Can you turn to the side?" Javier asked. "I need to see the profile of the movement." He turned me with his hands on my hips before I could move myself.

He positioned himself directly in front of me, close enough that I could see the flecks of different colors in his eyes. He raised my arm himself this time, his hand wrapped around my wrist. He moved it through the gesture he wanted while photographing the fabric's response.

"The thing about animation," Javier said, still holding my wrist, "is that it's not really about the movement itself. It's about what the movement communicates. Like right now, the way your arm moves says something different depending on your posture."

He released my wrist and moved behind me. His hands came to my shoulders.

"Stand like you normally stand," he said.

I stood the way I always stood, shoulders forward, weight balanced.

"Now I'm going to adjust you," Javier said. His hands pressed against my shoulders, pulling them back and down. "Feel the difference?"

I felt it, as though the way opening my chest changed something fundamental about how I occupied space.

"Now lift your arm again," Javier said, his hands still on my shoulders.

I raised my arm and the movement felt different, more confident somehow.

"See?" Javier said, moving to photograph from the side. "Same gesture, completely different meaning. The first way you were reaching for something you weren't sure you could get. This way you're reaching for something you know is yours."

He let his hands slide down from my shoulders to my upper arms, adjusting my position in small increments.

"In game animation we exaggerate this stuff," he continued, his hands warm through the thin fabric of the shirt. "But it's all based on real body language. The way people hold themselves tells you everything about what they're feeling." His voice was softer and soothing. It was lower.

He stepped in front of me again and demonstrated by changing his own posture, shoulders slumping forward and then pulling back. I saw what he meant about how it changed the entire communication.

"Can I show you something?" he asked.

I nodded and he moved behind me again, this time closer, his chest touching my back.

"I'm going to guide you through some positions," he said. "Just relax and let me move you."

His hands came to my waist and I felt my breath catch at the contact. But I forced myself to stay loose while he positioned me. He moved me forward, adjusted my weight. Then his hands slid up my sides to my shoulders and pulled them back.

"This is confidence," he said near my ear. "Openness. Someone who's comfortable with who they are."

He shifted me again, rolling my shoulders forward and down. His hands pressed against my upper back.

"This is defeat," he said. "Or exhaustion. Someone trying to make themselves smaller."

He continued moving me through different postures while explaining what each communicated. I became less aware of the specific positions and more aware of his hands on my body, the way he touched me with casual confidence, the warmth of him standing so close behind me.

"Last one," Javier said. His hands came to my hips and he turned me to face him.

We were inches apart and his hands stayed on my hips while he looked down at me.

"This is anticipation," he said quietly. "Someone waiting for something they might want."

We stood like that for a moment too long, his hands on my hips and my face tilted up toward his. Then Javier stepped back and the moment broke.

"That was perfect," he said, his tone shifting back to professional enthusiasm. "Your beautiful body is going to solve all my posture problems."

He thanked me and headed back downstairs. I stood in the middle of the living room wearing his oversized shirt trying to regulate my breathing. I changed back into my own clothes and returned to my desk, but I couldn't focus on billing for the rest of the afternoon. I knew he didn't really mean my beautiful body, that was just the way he talked.

When Colin came home, he came into the kitchen and wrapped his arms around me from behind in a gesture he made so rarely that it surprised me.

"You seem different lately," he said against my hair. "Happier. More energy."

"Do I?" I asked, trying to keep my voice neutral.

"Yeah. It's nice. I like seeing you like this."

He released me and cleared the table while I finished cooking. During dinner he commented again on how good my mood had been, how I seemed more engaged with things, how the change was strangely noticeable.

I agreed I'd been feeling good and didn't examine why too closely, didn't connect it to the modeling sessions or to Javier's hands on my body or to the way he looked at me like I was interesting rather than merely familiar. Colin seemed to like whatever change he'd noticed in me. I let him believe it was about us rather than about the hours I spent being positioned and photographed by the animator in our basement.

That night in bed Colin initiated sex with unusual enthusiasm. I responded with matching energy that surprised both of us. Afterward he held me close and said again how I seemed so happy. I curled against him and tried not to think about Javier's hands on my hips, his voice near my ear explaining what my body was communicating without.

Javier texted Saturday morning asking if we wanted to grab lunch at a Vietnamese place he'd discovered near his studio. Colin accepted before I could formulate a response. He didn't ask about how Javier had my number.

We met Javier there at noon and found him already seated at a table near the window, sketching something in his notebook he seemed to carry everywhere.

"I ordered spring rolls," he said when we sat down. "The ones here are incredible."

The spring rolls arrived and Javier was right about them. We ordered lunch while Javier talked about the game his studio was developing. He showed us concept art on his phone and explained the character dynamics. I found myself more engaged than I ever thought I'd be in a conversation about fantasy combat games.

"Ashlyn would be great at the posture work for the mage character," Javier said, turning his phone to show Colin. "She has a natural grace that's perfect for that flowing movement style."

"You've been helping him with his animation?" Colin asked me.

"Just some reference photos," I said. "Hands and arm positions."

"She's amazing at it," Javier said with enthusiasm. "Most people get stiff when they know they're being photographed but Ashlyn, she keeps it natural. It makes a big difference."

Colin nodded and seemed curious that I was helping with Javier's work. The conversation moved on to other topics. But I noticed as lunch continued that Javier and I had developed a shorthand from our weekday interactions, references to things that had happened during modeling sessions or conversations that Colin hadn't been part of.

When Javier mentioned the broken chair leg, I laughed and said something about how he'd gotten distracted showing off his software. Javier grinned and added that I'd been the one who'd actually fixed the chair while he was explaining particle effects.

"When did that happen?" Colin asked.

"Earlier this week," I said. "When he borrowed our screwdriver."

"Oh right," Colin said, but I could see him trying to place when I'd had time to go down to Javier's apartment and fix his chair.

Javier told a story about his art school roommate burning pasta so badly the pot was unsalvageable. I mentioned the dinner he'd made us and how much better his cooking skills were than ours. Javier laughed and said I'd been a good sous chef that night even though I'd fought against him with my body all the way.

"I wasn't fighting you!" I said with a laugh and I shoved his shoulder.

He pushed right back. Colin smiled along with us but I noticed him watching Javier and me with an expression I couldn't quite read. I realized we were excluding him without meaning to, our weekday dynamic carrying over into our three-person lunch in a way that highlighted how much time Javier and I had been spending together.

After lunch we walked back to our building together. Colin mentioned he had some work to catch up on that afternoon. Javier said he needed to tackle the dance sequence he'd been putting off. We parted ways in the driveway.

I was upstairs reading when Javier texted an hour later asking if I had time to help with movement references for the dance animation. Colin was in the bedroom on a video call with his research team. I texted back that I could come down, "but just for a bit, you bad man!"

Javier's apartment was warm and smelled like the coffee he always seemed to be brewing. He'd cleared space in the center of the room by pushing furniture against the walls.

"I need to capture a ballroom dance movement," he explained, pulling up reference videos on his computer. "But all the videos I'm finding are either

too formal or too modern. I need something in between, elegant but not stiff. Like you," he laughed.

He showed me clips of animated characters dancing and pointed out what wasn't working, the mechanical quality of their movements, the way they looked like they were following choreography rather than actually feeling themselves dancing.

"I don't know how to ballroom dance," I said.

"Neither do I," Javier admitted. "But I know the basic posture and movement. I just need to capture it from different angles."

He pulled me into the cleared space and positioned us facing each other, his right hand taking my left and his left hand coming to rest on my waist.

"This is the basic frame," he said, adjusting my free hand to his shoulder. "The movement comes from here."

He started swaying us gently side to side. I tried to follow his lead while he explained what he was trying to capture.

"The thing about partner dancing," Javier said, his hand warm against my waist through my shirt, "is that it's all about connection. The lead communicates through pressure and the follow responds. It's like a conversation in movement. Conversation using bodies."

He pressed against my waist and I moved in response. He smiled and said that was exactly right. We continued swaying while he explained the weight shift and the posture. Then he started adding actual steps, simple forward and back movements that required me to trust his lead.

"You're a natural," Javier said, pulling me closer to adjust our frame. "Most people fight the lead but you're just following the pressure."

His hand slid lower on my waist to demonstrate proper placement. We were close enough now that I could feel the heat coming off his body. He walked me backward through a series of steps and then spun me out and back. The movement brought us even closer together, my chest nearly touching his.

"Perfect," he said. His voice had gone quieter. "Hold this."

He released my hand and grabbed his phone to photograph our position from multiple angles, but his other hand stayed on my waist. He moved around us taking photos while I stood frozen in place, hyperaware of his fingers pressed against my side.

"Now I'm going to move you through the sequence," Javier said, pocketing his phone and taking my hand again. "Just let me guide you and

don't think about the steps."

He led me through a series of movements that flowed together, turns and dips and steps that required me to surrender control to him completely. His hand on my waist became the anchor point for every movement, pressing and releasing to communicate direction. I found myself responding before consciously processing what he wanted.

We moved through the sequence three times. Each repetition brought us closer together until there was almost no space between our bodies. Javier's hand had migrated from my waist to my lower back. When he dipped me backward his face was inches from mine.

"This is it," he said, holding the dip. "This is the connection I've been trying to capture."

We stayed frozen in the dip, his arm supporting my weight and his face so close I could feel his breath. Something changed in the air between us. The pretense of modeling for animation reference felt transparent in that moment, the physical intimacy too real to be purely professional.

My phone buzzed in my pocket and the moment shattered. Javier pulled me upright and I fumbled for my phone to find a text from Colin saying he'd finished his call early and was heading to the store, did I need anything.

"I should go," I said, typing a quick response to Colin.

"Yeah, of course," Javier said, stepping back and creating distance. "Thanks for the help. Those movements are going to make the animation come alive."

I headed for his door and climbed the stairs back to our apartment,. When I got inside I stood in the living room trying to process what had happened. My heart was racing and my skin felt flushed. I realized with uncomfortable clarity that I was disappointed Colin had texted when he did, disappointed the session had ended, disappointed to be back upstairs instead of still in Javier's arms.

The realization unsettled me enough that I forced myself back to my book, but I couldn't focus on the words. I kept feeling Javier's hand on my lower back, kept seeing his face inches from mine during the dip, kept replaying the way he'd said "this is the connection I've been trying to capture" with his arm supporting my weight.

When Colin came home with groceries I helped him unpack and told him I'd been reading all afternoon. He didn't question the explanation. That

evening we made dinner and watched shows and went through our normal routine. But I felt the distance between what I was doing and what I wanted to be doing. The gap between those things was starting to feel impossible to ignore.

That night in bed I lay awake after Colin fell asleep. I thought about Javier's hands on my waist, about moving in response to his guidance, about the moment suspended in the dip when everything else had fallen away. I told myself it was just modeling for animation reference, just helping a neighbor with his work, just innocent physical proximity that meant nothing beyond its practical purpose.

But lying in the dark next to Colin while thinking about another man's hands on my body, I knew I was constructing rationalizations that wouldn't hold up to honest examination. Something had shifted during that dance session, some boundary had moved. I wasn't sure I didn't want to find it again.

I bought two new shirts and a dress on my lunch break Thursday, telling myself I needed to update my work-from-home wardrobe because everything I owned had become shapeless and worn. The sales associate helped me find fitted tops in colors I didn't normally wear. When I looked at myself in the dressing room mirror I pictured Javier's reaction rather than Colin's, imagined him noticing the way the fabric draped or the color brought out my eyes. I bought torn white denim shorts, too. So unlike me to act on impulse.

I wore one of the new shirts the following Tuesday, a soft blue that the sales associate had said complemented my skin tone. I spent extra time on my makeup despite having no plans to leave the apartment. Colin had already left for the office. I made coffee and settled at my desk to process invoices while periodically checking my reflection in the computer screen.

Javier knocked around two in the afternoon. When I opened the door his eyes went immediately to my new shirt.

"That's a great color on you," he said. The observation sent warmth through my chest. "New?"

"Just something I picked up," I said, trying to sound casual.

"Well it looks really good," Javier said. Then he shifted to the purpose of his visit. "I have kind of an unusual request for today's session. The character I'm working on has this pivotal scene where she realizes she's

attracted to someone. I'm struggling to capture that moment of awareness. The physical tells that happen when attraction hits."

He showed me reference sketches on his tablet, a female character's face in various expressions that all looked generically pleasant rather than specifically attracted.

"They all look the same," I said.

"Exactly," Javier agreed. "I need to capture the real physical response. The pupil dilation, the slight parting of lips, the way someone unconsciously leans forward. All the micro-expressions that happen before conscious awareness."

"How am I supposed to help with that?"

"I was hoping you could try to access that feeling," Javier said. "Like method acting but for modeling. If you can imagine being genuinely drawn to someone and let that show on your face, I can capture the authentic response."

The request felt more intimate than anything he'd asked for before, but I found myself agreeing and following him downstairs to his apartment. He'd set up better lighting than usual, soft lamps positioned to eliminate harsh shadows. He'd cleared his desk chair for me to sit in.

"Get comfortable," Javier said, adjusting the lights. "We're going to take this slow. I want you to relax first and then gradually build to the feeling."

I sat in the chair and tried to relax while Javier positioned himself a few feet away with his phone ready.

"Close your eyes," he said, his voice taking on a much gentler quality than his usual energetic tone. "Take a few deep breaths. Let your face go completely neutral."

I followed his instructions and felt my facial muscles release tension.

"Good," Javier said. "Now I'm going to walk you through a scenario and I want you to let yourself actually feel it rather than perform it. Don't think about your face or your expression. Just experience the emotion and let it show naturally."

I kept my eyes closed and waited.

"Imagine you're in a room with someone," Javier said, his voice low and even, close to me. "Someone you see regularly but don't think about romantically. A friend, a colleague, someone familiar. Can you picture that person?"

I pictured Javier himself without meaning to. My breath caught.

"You're having a normal conversation," he continued. "Nothing unusual. But then something changes. Maybe the light changes and you notice their eyes. Or they smile and you see their mouth differently. Or they move closer and you become aware of their body in a way you weren't before."

His words created the scene in my mind with uncomfortable clarity. I felt my face respond to the imagined scenario.

"There's that first moment of recognition," Javier said. "Where you realize you're attracted to them. Your body responds before your mind can catch up. Let yourself feel that moment."

My heart rate increased and I felt heat rising in my chest and face.

"Open your eyes," Javier said quietly.

I opened them and found him much closer than he'd been before, close enough that the scenario he'd described didn't feel imaginary anymore. His phone was up and he was photographing me, but his eyes were on my face rather than the screen.

"So perfect," he said. "That's exactly the look. Stay with that."

I couldn't have broken eye contact if I'd tried. The awareness he'd asked me to imagine had become real. I was hyperconscious of his proximity, of the way his gaze moved over my features, of my own body's response to his nearness.

"Your pupils just dilated," Javier said, still photographing. "And your lips parted. These are the authentic tells I've been trying to capture."

He moved around me taking photos from different angles, but he kept talking in that low even voice.

"When someone is genuinely attracted," he said, "their whole body orients toward the object of attraction. It's involuntary. Look what you're doing right now."

I became aware that I'd shifted in the chair to face him more directly, that my body had unconsciously angled toward him while he moved.

"See?" Javier said. "You can't help it. The body knows what it wants before the conscious mind admits to it."

He crouched in front of my chair to photograph my face from a lower angle. Now we were at eye level with barely two feet between us.

"Think about what would happen next," he said, his camera forgotten in his hand. "If this were real. If the person you were attracted to was right in front of you like this."

My breathing had become shallow and I could feel my pulse in my throat. Javier's eyes moved from mine to my mouth and back. The action sent heat pooling low in my stomach.

"Your face is telling the whole story," he said. "Anticipation. Desire. The moment before something happens."

We stayed frozen like that, his face close to mine and my body screaming at me to close the distance. Then Javier's phone buzzed and the spell broke. He glanced at the screen and stood, creating space between us.

"That was incredible," he said, his tone shifting back to professional enthusiasm. "These photos are going to solve everything. The expression is so raw and authentic."

I stood on unsteady legs and Javier walked me to his door. When I climbed the stairs back to my apartment I felt shaky and overheated. I went to the bathroom and splashed cold water on my face. When I looked in the mirror I saw the expression Javier had been photographing, pupils still dilated and lips parted and face flushed with arousal I couldn't hide.

I forced myself back to work and spent the rest of the afternoon trying to focus on billing while my body buzzed with unspent energy. When Colin came home I was standing in front of the open fridge staring. He wrapped his arms around me from behind in greeting.

"Good day?" he asked into my hair.

"It's fine," I said, my voice coming out higher than normal. "Just work."

We ate dinner and watched shows. When we went to bed Colin reached for me in a way that suggested renewed interest rather than routine. I responded with an intensity that surprised both of us, pulling him closer and moving against him with an urgency I hadn't brought to our intimate life before.

Colin responded to my increased enthusiasm by trying things we hadn't done before, his hands more exploratory. I encouraged him by arching into his touch and making sounds I normally kept quiet. When he moved to go down on me, something he rarely initiated, I gripped his hair and let myself vocalize the pleasure rather than muffling it.

The sex was better than it had ever been. Afterward Colin held me close and said he was liking this version of me, this more expressive and adventurous version. I curled against him and tried not to think about whose

face I'd been picturing while he touched me, whose eyes I'd been remembering while my body responded to him with unusual fervor.

Colin fell asleep quickly but I lay awake replaying the session with Javier, the way his voice had guided me into feeling attraction, the way his proximity had made the feeling real rather than imagined. I'd crossed some internal line by letting myself actually experience desire for him rather than just modeling the appearance of it. I wasn't sure how to step back behind that boundary.

The new shirts hung in my closet as evidence of choices I'd been making without admitting their purpose. Lying in bed next to Colin while thinking about Javier's face inches from mine, I could no longer pretend I didn't know what I was doing. I was dressing for Javier. I was responding to his attention. I was letting the modeling sessions become something more than professional reference gathering.

Javier texted Wednesday evening asking if Colin and I wanted to come to his studio's game launch party Friday night. Before I could consider whether accepting was a good idea I'd already replied yes. Colin seemed pleased to be included in Javier's work life. I immediately started thinking about what I would wear.

Friday afternoon I left work early and spent two hours trying on different combinations of clothes, creating a pile of rejected outfits on the bed that grew until I'd emptied half my closet. The new dress I'd bought looked too formal. The casual jeans and nice top looked too understated. Everything I owned suddenly seemed wrong for an event where I'd be meeting Javier's colleagues, where I'd be visible in his professional world.

I finally settled on fitted black pants and a deep green silk top that I'd bought months ago and never worn. I spent forty minutes on makeup that looked natural but polished. When Colin came home and found me still in front of the mirror he looked surprised.

"You look great," he said. "Is this a fancy party?"

"I don't know," I admitted. "Javier just said launch party."

"Well you look really nice," Colin said. He changed into dark jeans and a button-down that was as dressed up as he ever got.

We met Javier in the driveway and he did a double-take when he saw me, his eyes moving over my outfit in a way that made my skin warm.

"You look amazing," he said. The way he said it felt different from Colin's compliment, more weighted. "That dress is perfect on you."

We drove to his studio in Colin's car. Javier sat in the back explaining what to expect, describing colleagues we'd meet and the game they were launching. When we arrived the studio was packed with people, music playing and monitors showing gameplay footage. I felt immediately overwhelmed at the crowd and noise.

Javier's hand came to my lower back as soon as we entered, a possessive gesture that guided me through the crowd while Colin followed behind us. He steered me toward a group of people standing near a display of concept art. His hand stayed on my back while he made introductions.

"This is Jim and Jen from character design," Javier said, "and this is Ashlyn. She's been my muse for the last few weeks."

The word muse hit me with unexpected force, claiming me in front of his colleagues in a way that felt both thrilling and dangerous. Jim and Jen smiled and shook my hand. Jen immediately started asking about the modeling work.

"Javier's been raving about your hand expressions," she said. "He showed us some of the reference photos and they're so much better than stock images."

Javier's hand pressed against my lower back. I felt the pressure like a message I couldn't decode. He introduced Colin as my husband and our upstairs neighbor. Colin shook hands and made polite conversation while Javier kept his hands on me.

We moved through the party and Javier introduced me to more colleagues. Each introduction included some variation of "my muse" or "the model I've been working with" that positioned me as part of his creative process. People asked questions about the modeling sessions and Javier answered enthusiastically, describing how my natural movement had solved animation problems he'd been struggling with for weeks.

"Come see the final animations," Javier said, guiding me toward a bank of monitors while Colin got absorbed in conversation with someone about shipping logistics and game distribution.

He pulled up character animations on one of the screens. I recognized my own hand gestures translated into the game character's movements. The character reached for an object and I saw my fingers in her fingers, saw the natural curve I'd made transformed into digital movement.

"That's incredible," I said, watching the character move through a scene with gestures I'd modeled.

"It's all you," Javier said, standing close behind me while we watched. "Your hands, your posture, your expressiveness. You made her come alive."

Other people gathered around to watch the animations. Javier explained which references had inspired which movements, pointing out moments where my specific gestures had solved technical challenges. The attention felt intoxicating, being displayed as the source of something creative and beautiful, being claimed as inspiration in front of all these talented people.

Javier's hand returned to my lower back and stayed there while we moved to look at other displays, while we got drinks from the bar, while we circulated through different groups of his colleagues. The constant contact felt like ownership, like he was marking me as his in a way that went beyond professional collaboration.

A woman named Sarah from the animation team pulled me aside to ask about my background, whether I'd done modeling before, whether I'd considered making it a regular thing. I explained I worked in billing and this was just helping a friend, but Sarah said I had natural talent and should think about pursuing it.

"Javier's work has improved dramatically since he started using you as reference," Sarah said. "The characters have this quality now they didn't have before. More human somehow."

Colin found me during this conversation and slipped his arm around my waist. I felt the difference between his touch and Javier's, the familiar comfort versus the electric awareness. Sarah excused herself and Colin pulled me closer.

"Everyone keeps talking about how much you've helped with the game," he said. "I had no idea the modeling sessions were such a big part of his process."

"It's just reference photos," I said, but the words felt hollow given everything I'd heard tonight about how integral my contributions had been. I knew it was more than just photos.

Javier appeared with three drinks and handed them to us. His fingers brushed against mine during the transfer in a way that felt deliberate. We stood together and Javier pointed out different people in the crowd, telling stories about studio dynamics and project challenges. His hand kept finding my lower back in a pattern that was becoming automatic.

Near the end of the party Javier gathered a group to show the final cut scene that featured the character I'd helped animate. We crowded around a

large monitor to watch. The character moved through an emotional moment, her body expressive and her posture communicating grief and determination. I saw my own movements translated into something powerful and affecting.

When the scene ended people applauded and several colleagues clapped Javier on the back. He pulled me forward and said the animation wouldn't have been possible without me. People turned to look at me and I felt exposed and valued simultaneously, visible in a way I'd never been in my billing job where I processed invoices anonymously.

We left the party around eleven and drove home through quiet streets. Colin was more talkative than usual, energized by the evening.

"That was really cool," he said. "Seeing how they make games, meeting all those creative people. And everyone was so complimentary about your work with Javier."

"It's just modeling," I said from the passenger seat while Javier sat silent in the back.

"It's more than that though," Colin continued. "You're inspiring his art. I'm really glad you found this creative outlet. You seem so much happier too since you started helping him."

I stayed quiet and watched streetlights pass while Colin talked about the party, about how impressive the studio was, about how talented Javier clearly was. I half turned and could see Javier watching me. When our eyes met he smiled in a way that suggested we shared something Colin couldn't access.

When we got home Colin headed straight upstairs but Javier caught my arm in the driveway, his touch light but stopping me from following.

"Thank you for coming tonight," he said quietly. "Having you there meant a lot. You're not just modeling for me. You're part of my creative process."

"I'm glad I could help," I said. The inadequacy of the response hung between us.

"You're more than help," Javier said, his hand still on my arm. "You're inspiration. You're the reason those animations work."

He released my arm and headed to the basement entrance. I stood in the driveway processing the weight of being called inspiration, of being displayed and claimed and valued in ways that had nothing to do with my ability to process invoices.

Upstairs Colin was already getting ready for bed. When I joined him he pulled me close and said again how proud he was that I'd found something creative to be involved in. I let him hold me and tried to reconcile the version of events he'd constructed, where I was helpfully modeling for a neighbor's work project, with the reality of what had happened tonight, where I'd been introduced as Javier's muse and positioned as central to his creative success.

That night I lay awake long after Colin fell asleep, replaying moments from the party, Javier's hand on my lower back and his colleagues treating me like I belonged in their creative world and the way he'd looked at me in the car. I'd crossed another threshold tonight by letting myself be displayed as his, by accepting the title of muse, by staying silent when Colin praised the creative outlet that was becoming something else I couldn't deny.

Javier texted Tuesday afternoon asking if I could help with an intimate scene he was struggling to animate. I stared at the message for a full minute before responding. Colin was on a scheduled video call with his research team that would run at least two hours. I told myself that helping Javier with technical animation problems was no different from the hand photos or the dance movements, even if he called them "intimate," whatever that meant.

I went down to his apartment and found him at his computer reviewing animation tests. When he turned to greet me his expression was more serious than usual.

"This is going to be more involved than the other sessions," he said. "The scene I'm working on is a romantic moment between two characters. I need to capture real physical intimacy. Not sex, but the moments leading up to it. The way people touch when attraction becomes physical."

He never had a need to couch things in euphemisms, that man.

"What do you need me to do?" I asked. My voice sounded steadier than I felt.

"I need you to be comfortable getting close to me," Javier said. "Close enough that I can photograph the real details of intimate contact. Hand placement, body language, the way people position themselves when barriers come down."

He showed me the scene he was animating, two characters alone after acknowledging mutual attraction. The storyboard showed them moving

from conversation to embrace to kiss. The animation tests he'd done looked mechanical and staged, missing the organic quality of real desire.

"I'll just be posing, right?" I said. "Like the dance movements."

"At first," Javier said. "But I might need you to actually engage with the actions rather than just pose through them. The authenticity shows in small details I can't capture if we're just going through motions."

I nodded and told myself this was still modeling, still reference work, still professional despite the intimate nature of what he needed to capture. Javier cleared space and positioned us standing close together, close enough that I could feel heat coming off his body.

"Start with just looking at each other," he said, his phone in one hand. "Like we did for the attraction photos. Let yourself actually see me rather than performing being seen."

I met his eyes and felt the same pull I'd felt during that earlier session, the same awareness of proximity and possibility. Javier held my gaze while taking photos. Then he set his phone down and brought both hands to my waist.

"I'm going to position us like the characters in the scene," he said.

His hands went to my waist and pulled me closer. Then one hand came up to my face and brushed hair behind my ear. The gesture was tender and intimate. I felt my breath catch at the contact.

"That response," Javier said quietly. "That's what I need to capture. Those involuntary reactions."

He picked up his phone and photographed my face while his other hand stayed against my cheek, thumb stroking along my jawline. I knew I should have stepped back or established some kind of boundary, but the touch felt too good to interrupt.

"In the scene," Javier said, "the male character touches her face like this. She leans into it. Can you show me what that looks like?"

I leaned into his palm. Javier's thumb moved to trace my lower lip. My lips parted at the contact and his eyes tracked the movement.

"Perfect," he said nearly inaudibly, still photographing. "Now he moves closer. Decides to act on what they're both feeling."

Javier stepped into my space until our bodies were nearly touching, his hand still on my face and his eyes searching mine for permission or resistance. I gave him neither, just stood frozen while he closed the remaining distance and brought his mouth to mine.

The kiss started gentle and exploratory, his lips soft against mine. I told myself this was part of the reference, part of capturing authentic intimacy for the animation. But when his tongue touched my lower lip and I opened for him, when my hands came up to grip his shirt and pull him closer, I stopped being able to maintain the pretense that this was professional.

Javier's phone dropped to the couch behind us and both his hands came to my face, angling my head to deepen the kiss. I made a sound into his mouth and pressed my body against his. He responded by walking me backward until I hit the wall. His hands moved from my face to my waist and then up my sides. When his thumbs brushed the sides of my breasts I arched into the touch.

"Is this okay?" Javier asked against my mouth, his hands stopping.

"Yes," I said. The word came out desperate.

His hands moved over my body with more confidence now, learning my shape through my clothes. I pulled at his shirt wanting to feel his skin. He helped me remove it and then his hands went to the hem of my own shirt.

"For the reference," I heard myself say, the rationalization automatic even as I lifted my arms so he could pull my shirt over my head.

"For the reference," Javier agreed, but his eyes on my body said something different.

His hands moved over my exposed skin and I shivered at the contact. When he lowered his head to kiss my neck I gripped his shoulders and tilted my head to give him access. His mouth moved down to my collarbone and his hands came to the clasp of my bra. I was seconds from letting him remove it when we heard footsteps directly overhead.

We both froze, Javier's hands on my back and his mouth against my shoulder. We listened to Colin moving around upstairs. The footsteps went to the kitchen and back. Then we heard the bedroom door close.

Reality crashed back and I stepped away from Javier, reaching for my discarded shirt with shaking hands. He picked up his own shirt and we dressed in silence. When I finally looked at him he was watching me with an expression I couldn't read.

"I should go," I said.

"Ashlyn," Javier started, but I was already moving toward his door.

I climbed the stairs to our apartment and went straight to the bathroom, locking the door and staring at my reflection. My lips were swollen and my face was flushed and I could still feel Javier's hands on my body. I'd kissed

him. I'd let him touch me. I'd been seconds from letting him remove my bra when Colin's footsteps had interrupted.

I splashed cold water on my face and tried to compose myself before leaving the bathroom. Colin was back in the bedroom on his call. I went to the kitchen and started preparing dinner with mechanical focus, chopping vegetables and trying not to think about Javier's mouth on my neck.

When Colin's call ended he came to the kitchen and wrapped his arms around me from behind. I went rigid at the contact before forcing myself to relax into his embrace.

"How was your afternoon?" he asked.

"Fine," I said. "Just worked on billing."

The lie came easily. I hated myself for how smoothly I could construct the deception. Colin released me and cleared the table while I finished cooking. We ate dinner and talked about his call and my work and everything except what I'd actually been doing while he was on that call.

That night Colin reached for me in bed and I responded with the same intensity that overtook me the previous week, channeling the arousal Javier had generated into sex with Colin. But while Colin touched me I thought about Javier's hands. When Colin kissed me I remembered Javier's mouth. When I came it was Javier's face I saw behind my closed eyes.

Afterward Colin held me and said again how much he loved this more passionate version of me. I curled against him and tried not to cry from guilt and confusion and the desire still humming through my body that Colin had satisfied physically but not actually addressed.

I'd crossed a line I couldn't uncross. I'd kissed another man. I'd let another man touch me intimately. I'd wanted more and would have taken more if circumstances hadn't interrupted. And the most disturbing part was that lying next to Colin in our bed, I wanted to go back downstairs and finish what Javier and I started.

The rationalization about modeling and reference work had revealed itself as transparent fiction. I could no longer pretend I didn't know what I was doing. I was cheating on Colin. Not technically, not yet, but in every way that mattered emotionally and physically.

I didn't go down to Javier's apartment Wednesday or Thursday, ignoring two texts asking if I was available to help with more reference work. I told myself I was establishing boundaries, protecting my relationship with

Colin, stopping things before they went too far. But Friday afternoon when Javier texted saying he really needed help with a scene he was struggling with, I found myself responding yes before I'd finished constructing the rationalization for why it was okay.

Colin was upstairs working on shipping data. I told him I was going down to help Javier with some quick reference photos. Colin barely looked up from his screens, just nodded and said that was nice of me, helping our new friend.

I knocked on Javier's door prepared to establish clear limits about what I would and wouldn't do, but when he opened it and I saw his face all my planned boundaries evaporated. He looked relieved and uncertain. He stepped aside to let me in without the usual confident energy.

"I wasn't sure you'd come," he said, closing the door behind me.

"I can't do what we did last time," I said, the words coming out in a rush. "That was too far. I have a husband upstairs and we can't..."

Javier kissed me before I could finish establishing the boundary, his mouth cutting off my protest. I kissed him back instead of pulling away. His hands came to my waist and pulled me against him. I gripped his shoulders and let him walk me backward to the couch. There was no camera in sight.

"We should stop," I said when he broke the kiss to move his mouth to my neck.

"Do you want to stop?" Javier asked against my skin, his breath warm and his lips trailing along the sensitive area below my ear.

"No," I admitted. The honesty felt both freeing and damning.

His hands moved under my shirt, palms sliding up my ribcage with painful slowness.

We kissed with the desperate intensity of people who'd been interrupted before finishing. There was no pretense about reference photos or modeling for animation. This was just wanting each other, acting on attraction that had been building through weeks of increasingly intimate contact. His tongue moved against mine and I made a sound into his mouth that came from somewhere deep and hungry, somewhere I'd kept locked away during all my years with Colin.

Javier's fingers found the hem of my shirt and he pulled back just enough to look at my face, silently asking. I lifted my arms in response and he pulled the fabric over my head, dropping it to the floor beside us. His eyes

moved over my exposed skin and I felt the weight of his gaze like a physical touch.

"You're so beautiful," he said, his voice rough with want.

This time when his hands went to my bra clasp I didn't stop him. I felt the hooks release and the straps loosen. Then he was sliding the lace down my arms and I was bare from the waist up in front of him. The basement apartment suddenly felt too warm. I was acutely aware of my own breathing, shallow and quick.

Javier's mouth moved from my lips to my jaw and then down to my neck, kissing and sucking in ways that would leave marks I'd have to hide later. The thought should have stopped me but instead it heightened everything, made it more real and urgent. His hands cupped my breasts and his thumbs brushed over my nipples. I arched into the contact and made sounds I'd been holding back during our previous session.

"I've been thinking about this since Tuesday," Javier said against my skin, his mouth moving lower. "About touching you like this. About hearing these sounds you make."

"Me too," I admitted. Saying it out loud made the betrayal real in a way it hadn't been when I'd only thought it.

His mouth closed around my nipple and I gasped, my hands moving to his hair to hold him against me. He used his tongue and teeth in ways that made my whole body respond, made heat pool low in my stomach and spread outward until I was trembling.

Javier's hand moved to the button of my jeans and he paused, his fingers resting against the fabric while he looked up at me from where his mouth was still on my breast. The question in his eyes was clear and I answered by lifting my hips, giving him access to undo the button and lower the zipper.

He hooked his fingers into the waistband and pulled, sliding the denim down my legs along with my shoes. Then I was on his couch in just my underwear while he was still fully clothed. The power dynamic should have made me feel vulnerable but instead it felt intentional, like I was giving him something Colin had never earned despite years together.

"Tell me what you want," Javier said, his hands resting on my thighs, warm and steady.

"Touch me," I said. I'd stopped trying to justify or rationalize. I only wanted what I wanted.

Javier's fingers traced patterns on my inner thighs, moving higher with agonizing slowness. When he reached the edge of my underwear he paused again. I could see the restraint in his expression, the way he was holding back and letting me decide even though his own desire was obvious.

"Please," I said, the word coming out broken and needy.

His fingers hooked into my underwear and pulled them down. I was completely naked in front of him while he was still fully clothed. He took a moment to just look at me, his eyes moving over my body with such obvious appreciation that I felt desired in a way I had never felt before.

"You're beautiful," Javier said again. This time his voice carried reverence that made my chest tight.

His hands moved up my inner thighs with slowness. When his fingers finally touched me I was already soaking wet. Javier made an approving sound deep in his throat and increased the pressure, his fingers moving in circles that made me grip the couch cushions.

I tried to stay quiet because Colin was directly above us, tried to muffle the sounds building in my throat. But when Javier lowered his head and his mouth replaced his fingers I stopped caring about noise. His tongue moved against me with skill and attention, learning what made me gasp and what made me arch straight up off the couch. His hands gripped my thighs to hold me in place while he worked on me.

The sensation built and built, more intense than anything I'd experienced. Javier added his fingers inside me while his mouth stayed focused on the sensitive bundle of nerves. The combination pushed me over the edge. I pushed against his mouth with my hand curled in his hair and my body arching off the couch. It seemed to last forever, waves of pleasure rolling through me while Javier stayed with me through all of it.

When I finally came down he kissed up my body slowly, mouth trailing over my stomach and between my breasts and along my neck until he found my lips again. I could taste myself on him and the intimacy of it made me pull him closer, made me want to give him the same overwhelming pleasure he'd just given me.

His erection pressed against my hip through his jeans and I reached down to touch him through the fabric. Javier groaned and pushed into my hand. I could feel how hard he was, how much he wanted this.

I pushed him to sit on the couch while I slid off and knelt between his legs.

I unbuttoned his jeans and pulled them down with his underwear. When I freed him, his cock was already hard and straining. I wrapped my hand around him and felt him pulse in my grip. Javier made a sound that was half groan and half my name.

I lowered my head and took him in my mouth. Javier's hand came immediately to my hair, fingers threading through the strands with a gentleness that contrasted with the desperation in his breathing. I'd performed this act for Colin out of obligation, mechanical motions to get him to completion, but with Javier I wanted to draw it out, wanted to hear the sounds he made, wanted to feel powerful and desired.

I used my tongue and my hand in combination, finding a rhythm that made Javier's grip tighten in my hair and his breathing become ragged. He was trying to stay quiet too, trying to muffle the sounds he was making, but small groans kept escaping and they made me work harder, made me want to completely undo him.

"Ashlyn," Javier said, my name rough and strained in his throat. "I'm close. You should..."

I didn't pull away, just looked up at him and kept going. The eye contact seemed to destroy his last bit of control. When he came I swallowed and stayed with him until he was finished, until his hand in my hair relaxed and his breathing started to even out.

"Come here," he said, his voice wrecked. He pulled me up to straddle his lap.

We kissed slowly and thoroughly, his hands moving over my naked body while I was completely exposed and he was only half undressed, jeans pushed down and shirt still on. The inequality felt symbolic of something I didn't want to examine, some dynamic of giving and taking that went deeper than just physical positions.

"We didn't actually just have sex," I said against his mouth, the distinction feeling important even though I knew it was meaningless.

"Not yet," Javier agreed. The "yet" hung between us like a promise and a threat.

I climbed off his lap and gathered my scattered clothes from where they'd been discarded across his living room. My underwear by the couch, my jeans near the door, my shirt crumpled on the floor. I dressed while Javier watched from the couch, pulling his own jeans back up but not bothering

with the button. When I was fully clothed again the magnitude of what I'd done crashed over me.

I'd just performed oral sex on another man while my husband sat upstairs. I'd let that man go down on me and give me feelings more intense than anything I'd ever felt. I'd crossed lines I couldn't uncross. The worst part was that I wanted to do it again.

I moved toward his door without looking back, needing to escape before I did something else I couldn't rationalize away.

"Ashlyn," Javier called. I stopped with my hand on the doorknob. "This isn't just physical for me. I need you to know that."

The confession hung in the air and I felt its weight, felt it asking for acknowledgment or reciprocation. I didn't respond because I couldn't, couldn't acknowledge that this meant something beyond sexual attraction, couldn't admit that I felt the same way. I turned the knob and climbed the stairs to our apartment, leaving him sitting on the couch in his disheveled state.

I went straight to the bathroom and closed the door, leaning against it while my heart hammered. When I finally looked in the mirror I saw guilt and satisfaction mixed together in my expression, saw swollen lips and flushed skin and eyes that looked different somehow, more alive.

I washed my face and fixed my hair, trying to erase the evidence of what I'd done, but I could still taste Javier in my mouth and still feel the ghost sensation of his hands on my body. I cleaned myself up as much as possible and emerged from the bathroom to find Colin still at his desk, exactly where I'd left him.

I went to the kitchen and started preparing dinner with mechanical focus, needing the familiar routine to ground me. I chopped vegetables and tried not to think about Javier's mouth on me, the way his tongue had felt, the sounds I'd made. I boiled water and tried not to remember how he'd looked when he came in my mouth, the way he'd said my name. I set the table and tried to pretend I was the same person who'd walked downstairs an hour ago.

"How was the modeling session?" Colin asked when he came to dinner. I flinched at the question even though his tone was casual.

"Oh fine," I said, focusing on serving pasta onto plates. "Just some quick reference photos."

The lie came so easily it frightened me, smooth and practiced as if I'd been deceiving him for years instead of weeks. Colin accepted it without question because he had no reason to doubt me, had never had reason to doubt me in all our time together.

We ate dinner and talked about his shipping data and my billing work, normal conversation about normal topics. I performed my role perfectly. I asked appropriate questions and made supportive comments and laughed at his observations. The entire time my body still hummed with the memory of Javier's hands and mouth.

That night in bed Colin reached for me and I responded with aggressive intensity that came from guilt and residual arousal combined. I pushed him onto his back and climbed on top of him with a forcefulness that clearly surprised him. I rode him hard and fast, chasing another high to prove to myself I could still want my husband.

When I came I kept my eyes open and forced myself to look at Colin's face instead of picturing Javier, forced myself to be present with the man I was actually with instead of the man I wanted to be with. Colin came quickly after, overwhelmed by my unusual aggression. Afterward he held me close and said something about not knowing what had gotten into me but he loved it.

I let him think my intensity was about us, about our relationship improving, about me becoming more sexual and adventurous with him. I let him construct whatever narrative made him comfortable while the truth sat between us unspoken and unexamined.

The compartmentalization was complete. Downstairs Ashlyn who performed oral sex on Javier and came apart under his mouth. Upstairs Ashlyn who made dinner and had aggressive sex with Colin and maintained the fiction of fidelity. I existed in both spaces simultaneously and separately. The ease with which I moved between them should have terrified me but instead felt like a skill I was perfecting.

I fell asleep in Colin's arms and dreamed about Javier's hands on my body. When I woke Saturday morning I knew I would go back downstairs again, knew the boundaries I'd tried to establish had never existed, knew I was going to keep doing this until something forced me to stop.

The "not yet" Javier had said echoed in my mind. I understood it wasn't a question of whether we'd have sex but when. The certainty of that

progression should have made me end things but instead just made me count the hours until I could go back down to his apartment and continue what we'd started.

I learned Colin's schedule with precision over the following two weeks, mapping when he'd be in the office versus working from home, when his video calls were scheduled, when he'd run errands or go to the gym. Tuesday and Thursday afternoons became my regular windows, three-hour blocks when Colin was reliably occupied and Javier was working from his apartment.

The first time I brought a change of clothes downstairs I told myself it was practical, that I didn't want to risk going back upstairs disheveled and having to explain my appearance. I left a shirt and clean underwear in Javier's bathroom, tucked behind his toiletries where they wouldn't be immediately visible but where I could access them when needed.

The second time I brought makeup remover and a compact mirror, basic supplies to fix my face before returning upstairs. Javier saw me adding items to his bathroom cabinet and didn't comment, just pulled me into his bedroom where we spent the next two hours establishing new boundaries of what we were willing to do while still maintaining the fiction that we weren't actually having an affair.

In fact, it was none of that. It was raw, fully naked, wild and intense in his bed, rolling around, tasting, bringing off each other multiple times.

We played, too. He rubbed the head of his cock against the front of my panties saying he's really interested in how my face changes, for an animation he was working on.

I was too breathless to object. "A character would writhe if you did that," I said, my body writhing under his touch.

When he pushed his cock inside the leg of my panties, I warned him. Soon we dispensed with the panties and he rubbed his bare cock against my exposed pussy. I could barely stand it. Nor could he, it seemed, him spilling himself all over my ribs and tits.

Or in my mouth if I reached him in time, which I loved to do, loved because of his attempts to restrain his groans, the intensity of the rigidity of his body head to toe before he lost it in and on me.

He was no better, making me come on his mouth, him teasing me so much knowing it was going to make me unable to keep quiet.

The hours we spent were a complete break to life upstairs. Except for how I dismantled Colin, hungry for it for reasons he could never imagine. Or he could, if he only looked.

By the third week I had a drawer in his bathroom with a complete change of clothes, makeup for repair work, even a toothbrush. The accumulation of my belongings in his space marked territory I hadn't consciously decided to claim, but every time I added something new it felt like settling in rather than overstepping.

The pretense about modeling and reference work became increasingly transparent. Javier would text asking if I could "help with some poses he was struggling with," and I would tell Colin I was "giving Javier feedback on his latest animations." Colin would respond with a thumbs up or a brief acknowledgment, never questioning why animation feedback required me to be in Javier's apartment for hours or why I needed to help so frequently.

Tuesday afternoon Colin texted that his meeting had run short and he was heading home. The message came through while I was naked in Javier's bed with his mouth on my breasts. I pushed him off and scrambled for my clothes, pulling on the shirt I'd left in his bathroom and running fingers through my hair while Javier watched from the bed.

"He's coming home early," I said, checking my reflection in Javier's bathroom mirror. "I need to get upstairs before he gets here."

"You look so freshly satisfied," Javier said, not moving from where he lay against the pillows. "He's going to know."

"He won't know because he won't look," I said. The certainty in my voice came from weeks of Colin not looking, not questioning, not examining what I was doing during my extended absences.

I fixed my makeup as much as possible and went to Javier's door, listening for sounds from upstairs before opening it. The building was quiet and I climbed the stairs as quietly as possible, but when I reached our floor I heard Colin's key in the lock.

I was five feet from our door when it opened and Colin stepped through. We nearly collided in the hallway. His eyes went to my face and I watched him register my flushed cheeks and swollen lips, watched his gaze track to my disheveled hair and the shirt that wasn't the one I'd been wearing when he left that morning.

"Hey," I said, trying to sound casual. "I was just coming up from Javier's."

"Oh yeah?" Colin said. His tone was carefully neutral. "More animation work?"

"He wanted to show me the latest character designs," I said. The lie came smooth and practiced. "Some of the movements we worked on last week made it into the final version."

Colin nodded and moved past me into the apartment. I followed while my heart hammered in my chest. He set down his bag and went to the kitchen for water. I waited for him to turn around and accuse me, to demand to know what I'd really been doing, to finally look closely enough to see the truth written all over my body.

Instead he drank his water and asked what I was thinking for dinner.

"I could make pasta," I said, the mundane response to his mundane question creating normalcy where there should have been confrontation.

"Sounds good," Colin said. "I'll clear it."

We moved into our established dinner routine. Colin didn't mention my appearance again, didn't ask why I'd changed shirts or why my makeup looked hastily reapplied, what happened to wearing a bra. He accepted my explanation about looking at character designs because examining it would require him to confront possibilities he clearly didn't want to acknowledge. That's what my theory was.

That evening while we were cooking together, Javier texted asking me to come back down when I had a chance, he had something to show me. I waited until after dinner to mention it to Colin.

"Javier wants me to look at something he finished," I said while loading the dishwasher. "Do you mind if I run down for a bit?"

"Sure," Colin said, not looking up from his phone. "I'll finish the dishwasher."

I went downstairs and Javier pulled me into his apartment and against his body, his mouth finding mine before I could speak.

"I couldn't wait until Thursday," he said between kisses. "I need to see you."

We ended up in his bedroom again, a trail of our clothes behind us. Javier and I got ourselves into a frenzy of sexuality, consuming each other to the point of complete distraction. He positioned himself between my legs high on his knees, me petting his cock down, pushing its length against my wet folds, lifting my knees, pointing my toes at the ceiling.

He slid back and pushed forward, and I pressed him down against myself and writhed with the touch. He was thoroughly soaked in me, lubricated. We joked in whispers about how to animate this. We both got good at bringing each other up to the very cusp, and holding each other there for extended periods, both of us unable to talk or even breathe.

Sometimes the head would catch on my pulsating edges, and we'd both warn each other and laugh it off. I rubbed my palm over the head, closed my fist around it right on top of my groin and he pumped himself into my fist pretending and nearly convincing himself he was inside me.

He inserted fingers inside me in time with how he drove his hips forward and back and nearly connived me he was there.

We walked around his place naked getting water and making out in the kitchen, looking at his work, me dropping to my knees to suck him, or him setting me on one of his tables to eat me out.

Then, on my back in his bed, his cock so close, so wet, he accidentally slipped inside me an inch. I gasped with shock and he froze above me. And then my body arched up involuntarily, my eyes rolled up in my head, and my fingernails dug into his hips.

I know he tried to save us. But he was no more able to stop than I was. He sank into me so easily because he was so soaked with me. I cried a high pitched gasp and his body jolted into mine he had filled me so deeply.

It was too late. I opened my eyes when he pulled all the way back out, we met each other's gaze, stopped all movement for three full beats, but then it was on. Weeks and weeks of restraint broke like a flood wall. Javier fucked me, I fucked him, we thrashed each other all over his bed even falling out and onto the floor and still we fucked without hardly even noticing.

I'd never experienced anything like it.

Afterward I lay in his bed trying to process that I'd just had sex with someone who wasn't Colin, that I'd cheated completely and unambiguously, that there was no rationalization left that could frame this as anything other than what it was.

"I need to get back upstairs," I said, already moving to gather my clothes.

"Stay a little longer," Javier said, his hand catching my wrist.

"Colin will wonder where I am."

"Colin hasn't wondered where you are in weeks," Javier said. The observation stung because it was true.

I dressed in the clean clothes from my drawer in Javier's bathroom and fixed my makeup and went back upstairs. Colin was exactly where I'd left him, on the couch with his phone. He looked up when I came in and smiled.

"How were the animations?" he asked.

"Really good," I said. "He's made a lot of progress." I even trusted my hand to muss his hair affectionately.

I sat beside him and we watched shows together. I tried to reconcile the person I'd been twenty minutes ago in Javier's bed with the person I was now on our couch. The compartmentalization was complete and disturbing in its ease. Colin's willful blindness enabled it in ways that made me angry at him even though I was the one betraying him.

That night, though, I told him I was having cramps. He left me alone. My body was too sore from Javier thrashing me around like an old rung hung on a line.

Thursday I went downstairs during my regular window and this time there was no pretense about animation work. Javier opened his door and pulled me inside and we went straight to his bedroom. We spent two hours having sex with an intensity that was urgent and all-consuming.

Between rounds we wondered around naked touching and drinking water and talking. Javier traced patterns on my skin. It was time out of time. It was a different life. I was a different person. I could physical feel the dissociation in me, the split.

I went back upstairs before Colin came home and made something for dinner and performed normalcy. When Colin touched me that night I responded with the an enthusiasm that had become my cover. I'd learned to channel the arousal Javier generated in my body into sex with Colin, learned to use my husband's body as evidence that everything was fine while my mind was still in Javier's bed.

The pattern solidified over the following weeks until it too became routine. Tuesday and Thursday afternoons I went downstairs and had wild, unrestrained sex with Javier being someone else, involved in art, talking about movement and emotion. Other days I processed invoices and evenings and weekends I maintained my steady and routine relationship activities with Colin.

The modeling pretense persisted in our text exchanges even though all three of us knew, had to know, it was fiction. Colin's continued acceptance of obvious lies became its own kind of permission. He must have convinced

himself sex with me, with the newly enhanced model, was worth the trade off.

I existed as two people in two relationships. The ease with which I maintained both should have destroyed me but instead made me more skilled at the performance of both. Downstairs Ashlyn was sexual and adventurous and emotionally vulnerable in ways upstairs Ashlyn never allowed. Colin accepted whatever version he was left with because he got what he wanted, too.

"Modeling go good today?" he'd say even as we undressed in front of each other getting ready for bed and not necessarily for sleep. I sucked him, I came on his mouth, I rode him forward and backward. Only occasionally did I beg off, having been fucked too hard by Javier too soon before. "Cramps" became shorthand for "need fuck recovery time."

The arrangement worked because everyone involved chose to let it work. I stopped trying to justify or rationalize and just accepted that this was my life now, divided between floors and men and versions of myself that became more distinct with each passing week. One girl managed invoices and a staid relationship with its own rewards in stability and predictability, the other talked art and took a sexy man's cum down my throat, over my tits, or deep into my pussy, wherever he wanted it.

Javier got a contract for a major animation sequence on a high-profile game. He came upstairs Thursday evening to tell us about it he was so excited. Colin congratulated him enthusiastically and asked about the timeline. Javier explained he had six weeks to complete work that would normally take three months.

"I'm going to be working insane hours," Javier said, his eyes flicking to me before returning to Colin. "Which means I'll need more reference work than usual. Ashlyn, I hate to ask this, but would you be able to increase our sessions? Maybe even daily instead of twice a week?"

The question hung in the air and I felt Colin's attention shift to me, waiting for my response to this request that would require me to spend significantly more time with Javier. Nobody was going to say what was actually being asked. Yes, he would also be animating. But that was beside the point.

"I have my own work," I said carefully. "But I could probably make it work for you. Evenings, say, weekends." I glanced at Colin.

"That would be amazing," Javier said. "I really couldn't do this project without you. The character work you've inspired is what got me this contract in the first place."

Colin reached over and squeezed my hand, his expression proud.

"You should definitely help him," he said. "This is a huge opportunity for Javier, and you're clearly the cog in his creative gears."

I looked at him encouraging me to spend more time with the man I was sleeping with and wondered if he really did know, or if in fact there was different kinds of knowing. I felt anger and guilt mixing together in my chest. Colin's willful blindness had progressed to active facilitation. I couldn't tell if he genuinely didn't see what was happening or if he'd chosen not to look because looking would require action.

"Okay," I said. "Evenings. Weekends."

Javier's expression showed relief and something else I didn't want to examine in front of Colin. We finished dinner talking about the project and the studio and everything except what daily sessions would actually mean for all of us.

The new schedule started the following Monday. Colin left for the office at eight and by eight-thirty I was downstairs in Javier's bed, his mouth on my neck and his hands removing my clothes. We'd have sex before any modeling. We'd have sex too during the modeling, and more sex after it.

"I've been thinking about this since Thursday," Javier said against my skin, his lips trailing from my neck to my collarbone while his fingers worked the buttons of my shirt. "Three days was too long."

"We were together Thursday," I said, my hands moving over his back, feeling the warmth of his skin through his thin t-shirt.

He pulled my shirt off and tossed it aside, then reached for the clasp of my bra with the familiarity of someone who'd done this dozens of times. The bra joined my shirt on the floor and Javier's hands moved to cup my breasts, thumbs brushing over my nipples in a way that made me gasp.

I arched into his mouth and threaded my fingers through his hair, holding him against me while he used his tongue and teeth in ways that made coherent thought impossible.

Javier's hand moved to the button of my jeans and he undid it without breaking contact with my breast, then lowered the zipper and slid his hand inside my underwear. When his fingers found me already wet he made a

sound of approval against my skin and increased the pressure, circling and teasing until I was making small desperate sounds.

He pulled my jeans and underwear down in one motion and I kicked them off. Then I was completely naked. He stood and stripped off his own clothes. When he was finally bare he positioned himself between my legs and paused, his cock hard against my entrance but not yet pushing inside.

Then he pushed into me with more force than usual, possessive and claiming. I wrapped my legs around him and matched his intensity. We'd developed a physical language over the weeks, learned what the other liked, what made us both lose control. Sex with Javier was consuming in a way it had never been with Colin, urgent and honest and completely absorbing.

He set a punishing rhythm, his hands gripping my hips hard enough to leave marks. I met each thrust with my own movement, chasing the building pressure. The bed frame hit the wall with rhythmic thumps and I didn't care who might hear, didn't care about anything except the feel of him inside me and the way he was looking at me like I was something he needed rather than just wanted.

I slid my hand between us and found the sensitive bundle of nerves, circling with the same rhythm he was hitting me with. The dual sensation pushed me rapidly toward the edge. Javier watched my face while I touched myself, his expression intense and focused. When I came he swallowed my cries with his mouth, kissing me deeply while my body clenched around him.

He followed moments later, pushing deep and holding himself there while he pulsed inside me. The intimacy of feeling him come undone was almost as intense as my own had been.

Afterward we lay tangled together in his bed and Javier traced patterns on my skin while I floated in the particular satisfaction that came from being thoroughly wanted. His fingers moved from my shoulder down my arm and back up again, idle touches that felt possessive even in their gentleness.

"You're different down here," Javier said, his fingers moving along my collarbone and then down between my breasts. "Completely uninhibited. Like you've been waiting your whole life for permission to be this version of yourself."

"Maybe," I admitted, watching his hand move over my body.

"Do you think he knows?" Javier asked, his hand sliding lower to rest on my stomach. "Colin. Does he know what you do down here?"

"He doesn't want to know," I said. "If he wanted to know he'd see it."

Javier was quiet for a moment, his hand still resting on my stomach. Then he rolled on top of me again and this time his touch was gentler, exploratory rather than urgent. He kissed my mouth softly and then moved down to my neck, taking his time, trailing kisses along my collarbone and then lower to my breasts.

He took one nipple in his mouth and used his tongue in slow circles that made me arch into him. His hand moved down my body to slip between my legs. I was sensitive from our earlier intensity but his touch was light and teasing, building pleasure gradually rather than demanding it.

"I love the sounds you make," Javier murmured against my breast, his fingers moving in lazy patterns. "The way you gasp when I touch you here."

He demonstrated by increasing the pressure and I did gasp, my hips lifting to meet his hand. He continued his slow exploration of my body, mouth and hands working in coordination to build me back up toward another peak. This time when I came it was slower and deeper, waves of pleasure rolling through me while Javier watched my face with obvious satisfaction.

He kissed down my body and I knew where he was heading, knew what he wanted to do. I opened my legs wider in invitation. His mouth settled between my thighs and he used his tongue with skill and patience, exploring and tasting until I was gripping his hair and making sounds I'd never made with Colin.

When he made me come again with his mouth I arched off the bed and cried out without restraint. Javier stayed with me through the aftershocks, gentle now, bringing me down slowly. He kissed up my body and when his mouth found mine again I could taste myself on him and the intimacy of it made me pull him closer.

We spent three hours in his bed before I finally said I needed to get work done, and even then Javier pulled me back for one more kiss that turned into another twenty minutes of touching before I could extract myself. My body felt used and satisfied in ways I'd never known were possible, every nerve ending alive and sensitive.

I showered in his bathroom and dressed in the clean clothes from my drawer. When I looked in his mirror I saw flushed skin and swollen lips and

satisfaction written across my features. There were marks on my neck that I'd have to hide with makeup, fingerprint bruises on my hips that Colin would see if I wasn't careful.

I went upstairs and immediately shifted into work mode, sitting at my desk and processing invoices with the same focused attention I always brought to billing. The transformation was automatic now, flipping a switch between downstairs Ashlyn who was sexually adventurous and emotionally available and upstairs Ashlyn who was efficient and reserved and performed appropriate wife behaviors.

My body still hummed with the memory of Javier's hands and mouth. I had to consciously keep myself from touching the marks on my neck or shifting in my chair from the pleasant ache between my legs. The physical evidence of what I'd been doing made it harder to compartmentalize, harder to pretend I was just the billing clerk working from home.

Colin came home at six and found me at my desk finishing the day's work. He kissed the top of my head in greeting. The casual affection felt wrong after the intensity of what I'd shared with Javier. I had to resist the urge to flinch away.

"How was your day?" he asked.

"Good. Just billing work," I said, the lie so automatic I didn't even register it as deception anymore.

"Did you help Javier at all?"

"We did a session this morning," I said, my face heating at the understatement. "Some new character poses he needed."

Colin nodded and accepted the explanation without question. We moved into our evening routine of making dinner together. I performed my role perfectly, responding to Colin's touch with appropriate warmth, laughing at his comments about the show, existing as the version of myself he expected and wanted.

But underneath the performance my mind was still downstairs, still feeling Javier's hands on my body and his mouth between my legs and the way he'd looked at me while he moved inside me. The disconnect between what I was doing and what I was thinking felt wider than ever.

After dinner when we might have sat on the couch together, I told him it was time. "Maybe don't wait up, we might go very late."

"Good luck with it," he said, and he kissed me on my lips.

“Just going to...” I said not finishing the sentence as I threw some clothes in a bag without explanation and went out to go downstairs to my lover’s lair.

We did some work, too.

The pattern continued through the week. Every evening I would go downstairs and spend late hours with Javier, exploring all the sexuality and emotional intimacy I'd discovered with him. We'd have sex multiple times, in different positions, with varying intensity. Sometimes urgent and demanding, sometimes slow and tender. He learned my body with meticulous attention, discovered what made me gasp and what made me scream, figured out exactly how to touch me to make me come apart.

Between rounds we'd talk, lying tangled in his sheets while he traced patterns on my skin and asked me questions about my childhood, my dreams, my frustrations with work and life. I found myself being more honest with Javier, admitting things I'd never voiced.

Then I would return upstairs late at night and shift seamlessly into wife mode, but not quite able to get over the cramps.

Colin made dinner one night to give me a break. I sat at the table watching him move around our kitchen with familiar efficiency. I felt the vast distance between us like a physical thing. He didn't know me anymore, if he ever had. He didn't know about the drawer of clothes in Javier's closet, my make up on his counter, or the daily sessions that had little to do with animation or the way I come apart under Javier's touch.

And more damning than my betrayal was Colin's continued refusal to see it, his active encouragement of the arrangement while he maintained the comfortable fiction that I was just helping a neighbor with creative work.

That weekend Javier texted asking if I could come down Saturday afternoon for a longer session. I told Colin I was going to help Javier with an intensive animation sequence. Colin barely looked up from his shipping data, just said that was nice and went back to his screens.

I spent four hours in Javier's bed Saturday. This time we didn't rush through anything. He took his time undressing me, kissing every inch of exposed skin, using his mouth and hands to map my body with deliberate thoroughness. He made me come three times before he even entered me. When we finally had sex it was slow and deep and felt more like making love than fucking.

Afterward we lay facing each other and Javier brushed hair from my face with gentle fingers.

I kissed his fingers and then his mouth. We stayed in bed until early evening, alternating between talking and touching and occasionally dozing tangled together. When I finally went back upstairs Colin asked if the session had been productive. I said it had been very productive. Colin smiled and returned his attention to his work. I stood in our kitchen processing the complete dissolution of boundaries between my two lives.

We worked late Monday, actual work, before we fell exhausted in his bed.

I woke Tuesday morning still in Javier's bed with his arm around my waist and morning light filtering through his basement windows. For a moment I forgot which version of myself I was supposed to be. Then I heard Colin's footsteps overhead heading toward the shower and reality reasserted itself.

"Oh my god, I need to get upstairs," I said, extracting myself from Javier's embrace.

"Stay," he murmured, still half asleep, his hand sliding down to grip my hip and pull me back against him. "Just a few minutes."

"Colin will notice I'm not there," I said, though even as I said it I knew it wasn't true. Colin rarely noticed my presence or absence anymore, had stopped tracking my movements or questioning my time.

Javier's hand moved from my hip to between my legs, fingers sliding through the evidence of what we'd done multiple times during the night. I was still sensitive and I gasped at the contact, my body responding even as my mind insisted I needed to leave.

"He won't notice," Javier said against my neck, his fingers moving in slow circles. "And even if he does, he won't say anything."

I knew he was right but I still pulled away and dressed in yesterday's clothes. I went to Javier's bathroom to make myself presentable. The mirror showed marks on my neck and chest that I covered with concealer from my drawer. I fixed my hair and tried to erase the obvious evidence of the night spent in another man's bed.

When I climbed the stairs to our apartment Colin was in the kitchen making coffee. He looked up when I entered.

"Morning," he said. "You're up early."

"Couldn't sleep," I said, the lie automatic and smooth. I didn't expect him in the kitchen. He said nothing about my absence from our bed all night.

Colin accepted all without comment and handed me a cup of coffee. We stood in the kitchen together existing in separate realities. He saw a wife who was now sometimes not even in his bed. I was a woman who'd spent the night having sex with the downstairs neighbor and had just snuck back into her own apartment.

Colin left for the office at eight and I went back downstairs at eight-fifteen. Javier pulled me into his bed still warm from where I'd left it an hour before. He was already hard when I slipped under the covers. His mouth found mine while his hands worked to remove the clothes I'd just put on.

"This is ridiculous," he said against my neck, pulling my shirt over my head. "Sneaking around like we're doing something wrong when he clearly doesn't care what you do."

"He cares," I said, though I wasn't sure I believed it anymore. "He just doesn't want to look."

Javier made a sound of disagreement and unhooked my bra, tossing it aside before his mouth moved to my breast. His tongue circled my nipple and I arched into him, my hands moving to his hair to hold him against me.

His hand slid between my legs and found me already wet. He made that approving sound deep in his throat that I'd come to crave. He positioned himself between my thighs and entered me slowly, both of us still drowsy and unhurried. The intimacy of early morning sex felt different from our usual intensity.

We moved together with lazy rhythm, his body covering mine. He kissed me deeply while he moved inside me. The pace was slow and thorough, building pleasure gradually rather than racing through it. When I came it was in gentle waves rather than crashing intensity.

Javier followed moments later, his face buried in my neck and his breath hot against my skin. Afterward we lay tangled together for another twenty minutes before I finally insisted I actually needed to go for a walk and also get some work done.

I dressed again and went for a real walk this time, needing the cold morning air to clear my head and create some distance from the complete dissolution of boundaries that was my life now. When I returned I settled at

my desk upstairs and processed invoices until noon, forcing myself to focus on the familiar routine of billing work.

At noon I went back downstairs and Javier made us lunch. We ate together in his small kitchen while he told me about the animation problems he was solving. I understood maybe a quarter of the technical details but loved watching his face while he talked about his work, the way his eyes lit up when he described a breakthrough or the frustration that showed when something wasn't working.

"I need to work," I said eventually.

"Stay down here. Work from my couch. I like having you in my space."

I went upstairs and got my laptop and returned to Javier's apartment. I spent the afternoon processing invoices from his couch while he worked on animations at his desk. We existed in comfortable parallel focus, occasionally breaking to make coffee or show each other something on our screens.

Every so often I'd look up and find Javier watching me instead of his monitor. The expression on his face was so openly affectionate that it made my chest tight. This wasn't just sex anymore, wasn't just physical release or convenient availability. We'd crossed into something deeper and more complicated. I didn't know how to navigate it. I went over to him, hugged him from behind, kissed the back of his head, smelled his hair.

Around six I went upstairs. At six-thirty Javier texted asking if he could make us a meal. I told Colin that Javier wanted to come up for dinner and Colin said that was fine, seemed pleased even, like having our neighbor join us was a nice social development rather than a symptom of our collapsed boundaries.

Javier came upstairs and cooked something fabulous while Colin cleared the table. We fell into easy coordination in the small kitchen. Javier's hand rested on my lower back while I stirred sauce. He fed me a piece of bread with olive oil, his fingers lingering at my lips in a way that made me flush. It was intimate. Then he kissed me, and not on the cheek either, fully on the mouth, tongues involved.

I was so surprised by it, I turned into it, I took it and sought more of it. I was kissing him as much as he was kissing me. Javier's hand came up and cupped my breast through my top.

Colin watched these intimate gestures without comment or reaction. How could he not see what was happening right in front of him? How could he

watch another man touch me like this and say nothing?

We sat down to eat and immediately Javier and I fell into the shorthand we'd developed from spending hours together daily. He referenced something I'd said that morning while we were still in bed. I built on the joke. He touched my hand while making a point. We existed in our own bubble while Colin participated peripherally.

"The animation sequence is really coming together," Javier said to Colin. "Ashlyn's contribution has been invaluable. I literally couldn't have done this project without her."

"I'm glad she could help," Colin said. His tone was genuinely warm. "It's been good for her to have this creative outlet. She seems so happy."

I looked at my husband praising my affair with another man and felt a complex mixture of emotions I couldn't parse. Colin wasn't stupid or oblivious by nature. He'd chosen this blindness, had actively constructed a narrative that let him avoid confronting reality, however obvious that reality was.

It was like the new routine was acceptable because it was at least a routine, and routine mattered more than anything else. Even more than who was fucking his wife.

After dinner Javier helped with dishes while Colin retreated to his laptop. We stood close together at the sink with our bodies touching at every point of contact. Javier's hand slid under my shirt to rest on my bare skin. I leaned back against him while we finished cleaning up. We made out, long kissing pauses, hands exploring under clothes.

When we finished Javier just looked at me. I told Colin I'd be downstairs for a while.

"Take your time," he said without looking up from his screen. "I'll probably just work and then head to bed."

"I might not..." I started but I couldn't finish the sentence. Javier was pulling me by the wrist, making me laugh.

I followed Javier downstairs and the door had barely closed before he was on me, pressing me against the wall and kissing me with desperate hunger. His hands were already working on my jeans and I helped him, needing this as much as he did.

We didn't make it to the bedroom. Javier lifted me and I wrapped my legs around his waist. He entered me right there against the wall, both of us still partially clothed. The urgency was different from our earlier sessions,

fueled by the frustration of having to hide what we were to each other. When I came it was with my face buried in his neck to muffle the sounds.

Javier carried me to the bedroom and we shed the rest of our clothes. This time when we came together it was slower. He took his time exploring my body, relearning every curve and hollow. I did the same with him, mapping the muscles of his back and chest and the sensitive spots that made him gasp.

We made love for over an hour, trying different positions, alternating between tender and intense. By the time we finished we were both exhausted and thoroughly satisfied. Javier pulled me against his chest and said he wanted me to stay the night.

"Colin will notice," I said automatically, the protest coming from habit rather than actual concern.

Javier only shrugged.

I texted Colin saying I was staying the night downstairs "to help Javier work through the night on his deadline." Colin responded with a thumbs up and a message saying not to work too hard. I replied saying "see you in the morning I guess."

I showed Javier the text and he laughed and pulled me closer. After a particular loud and rambunctious session, we fell asleep tangled naked together in his bed while Colin slept alone upstairs.

The pattern continued over the following weeks until it became completely normalized. I spent most of my weekday daytime hours working hard as ever but slipping downstairs now and then to his bed to have sex multiple times a day or to eat meals together, existing in a relationship that had all the markers of domestic partnership. Evenings I was with Colin. Nights I was with Javier.

Our physical intimacy had evolved beyond just the initial excitement of new sexuality. Javier had learned exactly how to touch me to make me come in minutes or draw it out for an hour. He knew that I liked it when he talked during sex, when he told me how good I felt or how beautiful I looked or what he wanted to do to me. He knew that I got off on watching us in the mirror, on seeing my body respond to his touch.

And I'd learned him too. I learned that he loved it when I took control, when I pushed him onto his back and rode him while he gripped my hips. I learned that he had a thing for going down on me, that he could spend an hour between my legs and seem to enjoy it as much as I did. I learned that

after intense sessions he liked to hold me close and stroke my skin while we talked, creating emotional intimacy that matched the physical.

Evenings, Javier started coming up so he and I could cook together and the three of us would enjoy fabulous dinners. Javier would go down and Colin and I would watch some shows and talk about stuff and go on maintaining the fiction that I was still his wife in any meaningful sense. In the late evening, we'd embrace and I'd ride him, suck him, let him have me in any way he could think of.

And then I'd dress if even just partially, said it was time to go, and I'd go downstairs for the night, where Javier would utterly take me apart the same way I had just taken my husband apart.

I'd came up in the morning sometimes in only one of Javier's t-shirts and panties, have coffee with Colin, talk about the day. Then it was work, either at the office or at home, for one or the other of us.

Making dinner, Javier liked to push things, grinding me in the kitchen, teasing me, feeling me up, kissing me fully and openly. "Back in a moment," I said to Colin. "Watch the sauce doesn't boil?"

He nodded.

Javier and I rushed downstairs and he took me from behind, jolted my body, made me scream. We came back up disheveled and only partially satisfied, to come back into the kitchen and serve Colin the meal we'd made.

"This is..." he paused, savoring it in his mouth, "Perfecto!"

We watched a show and when I came back with drinks, Javier snatched at my wrist and pulled me down into his lap. I shrugged at Colin who made a point of staring at the show.. We made out until we couldn't take it anymore, and I told Colin I'd be "down there."

After we romped in his bed, Javier, still catching his breath, said, "How does he take it? Knowing I have you like this down here?"

I thought a moment. "Could say the same thing to you," I said. "How do you take it, knowing I'm up there with him?"

"You hardly are anymore," he said, and we both laughed and rolled around and he entered me again, so hard all the time, that Javier.

But his question did stick in my head. Until one time I had to rush upstairs to get something I forgot. I surprised my husband. He had been lying on the floor with his ear on the vent, stroking himself. He was hard when I found him.

“So you can hear me,” I said.

I sat up and covered himself and shut his eyes. It took him a long time to answer, but he finally managed to. “I’ve heard... I’ve listened to everything from the start. I always knew.”

“All of it?” I was in no position to shame anyone. I thought he was well and truly asleep, and I had on only Javier’s t-shirt and nothing else, not even panties.

He only nodded. “It’s so fucking hot, Ashlyn.”

I kissed him, told him I didn’t mind, and went back downstairs to my lover, who was never going to learn about that fact.